

about 3,700 words

The Hills Above Allentown

by

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There are hills above Allentown, and the one that sits closest over the city is South Mountain, and if you drive up it after dark you will come to a pull-off on the city side, a wide spot of gravel big enough for maybe six cars, with a steel guardrail at the edge of it. On the far side of that rail the mountain falls away fast, red sumac and little crooked oaks all the way down, and down below them the whole town is spread out under you like somebody spilled a jar of lights across a dark table. Kids have been climbing up there for as long as there has been a road. I'm going to tell you about four of them, and a Friday in October, and what came up the hill at them while they stood at that rail.

Dani Peña's mother zipped the Bible into the front pocket of Dani's backpack every morning at the kitchen table, the same way she zipped Dani's coat up to her chin and pulled her braid out from under the collar. It was a small Bible, about the size of a paperback, in Spanish, with a blue vinyl cover and a zipper that ran around three sides of it like a pencil case. Her

mother had bought it in Santiago the week before they flew up, and on the first page she had written Daniela Peña Almonte in ballpoint, pressing hard enough that you could read the name backwards from the other side of the paper. Dani was twelve. Two years she had lived in Allentown, and she had spent both of them in the English learner class down the hall at South Mountain Middle School, and in those two years she had never once opened that pocket during a school day. All she knew about it during the day was that the backpack hung a little heavier on the left.

That Friday the last bell let out at the regular time and the four of them met on the front steps on Emaus Avenue. A custodian was out on the walk with a push broom, sweeping a busted bag of Takis into a dustpan, and the wind kept picking up the little red pieces and carrying them off down the steps away from him.

Isaiah Whitfield had the plan, the way he usually did. Thirteen years old and in the eighth grade, he had his phone already screwed into a little tripod with bendy legs from his birthday, and he was holding it up in front of him like a flashlight.

"Everybody keeps posting the lights," he said. "White lights over South Mountain, real low, no sound. Two hundred comments under every video, and it's aliens, it's ghosts, it's the end of the world." He turned the phone so they could see the screen. "It's drones. Or it's planes coming into the airport and the angle is weird. I'm going to get it clear, from close, and put it up, and that's the end of it."

"From close how?" Yadiel asked.

"From the pull-off. Right over top of where they come up."

Yadiel Rosario was thirteen too, and the tallest of them by a head. That day he had on his older brother's William Allen hoodie with the canary on the front, and the sleeves hung down

past his fingers. His family was Puerto Rican, and his abuela lived with them in the back bedroom of a row house off Fourth Street, and she prayed out loud in the kitchen every morning over the radio with the volume up, so the whole house got prayed for whether it was awake or not.

"My abuela says don't go up the mountain after dark," he said.

"So we come down before dark."

"Sunset is at six-thirty," Dani said. At lunch she had looked it up on her phone, because she had known since Wednesday that they were going whether she said yes or no. "We have three hours."

The fourth one was Bryce Kressley, who was eleven, a sixth grader, small for it, and he lived two doors down from Isaiah with his grandmother, who said "ach" when she dropped a pot lid and still kept a jar of pickled eggs in the refrigerator door. Bryce had her binoculars around his neck in a cracked leather case. Every fall she used them for counting hawks up at Hawk Mountain, and she had let him take them on the condition, which she said twice at the front door, that they came home with him by dark.

They went up Emaus a couple of blocks and turned up a side street that climbed and kept climbing, past the last houses, where the sidewalk quit and the pavement got patchy and then there was just a gravel shoulder and the trees. Everybody who went to South Mountain knew the path. It started behind a yellow sign that said the road was not maintained in winter, and it went up through the woods in a long zigzag, worn down to dirt and roots by about a hundred years of kids.

It was a warm afternoon for October, warm enough that they were sweating inside ten minutes. The oaks were just starting to go brown, but the poplars had dropped already, and the

path was covered in leaves that went in with a dry crunch and slid a little before they caught. Dani was in her school shoes, flat black ones with no grip on the bottom, and twice she went down on one knee in the leaves. The second time Yadiel stuck his hand back without turning around and she took it and he pulled her up the steep part, and neither one of them mentioned it afterward. Halfway up, off to the side of the path, there was a single roller skate lying on its back in the leaves, white with pink laces, and all four of its wheels were gone. Bryce poked at it with his sneaker as he went by. That was all anybody did about it.

Isaiah talked most of the way up, about frame rates and the zoom on his phone, and about how people believed whatever they saw in a video if it was blurry enough. Bryce asked him what he thought it was if it turned out not to be drones, and Isaiah said it would be drones.

"But if it isn't," Bryce said.

"Then it's planes."

"But if it isn't planes."

Isaiah stopped on the path and put both of his hands on his knees to breathe. "My mom says people see what they need to see," he said. "She says that's what church is. People needed a story, so they got one. She quit going when I was eight."

Yadiel said, "My abuela says your mom is going to come back."

"Your abuela says that about everybody."

"She's been right about a lot of everybody," Yadiel said, and he went on up the path ahead of them, and that was the end of that.

They came out of the trees at the top a little after five, onto the shoulder of the road just above the pull-off, all four of them breathing hard and red in the face. Nobody else was there. A car had been there not long before, because there was a fresh set of tire tracks swung around in

the gravel, but it was gone now, and the only sound was the wind going through the sumac below the rail and, way down, the traffic on the streets.

The sumac below the guardrail had gone red the way it does in October, a deep red like a stop sign, and it ran down the slope in a thick tangle into the scrub oak and then down to the backs of the first houses. The sun was dropping on their left, way out toward Trexlertown, flat and orange, and it laid long shadows from every church steeple and smokestack across the rooftops. Right in the middle of downtown the PPL Building stood up out of everything else, tall and pale, and the top of it already had its lights on, same as every night anybody in that town can remember. Hamilton Street ran off east from there in a line of streetlights coming on one at a time. Past that was the dark cut where the Lehigh River went through, and way off to the right, past where the hills folded together, the old steel stacks in Bethlehem were lit up in colored lights against the sky. A freight train was coming along the river, slow, and every time it got to a crossing it gave two long pulls on the horn, like a man leaning on it, and the sound took a second or two to climb the mountain to them.

Isaiah bent the tripod legs around the top of a guardrail post until it held, and he pointed the phone out over the sumac and hit record. The guardrail was cold. Dani could feel it through the sleeve of her coat where she leaned on it. Somebody, a long time ago, had painted J.R. + M.T. on the post next to her in silver paint, and the paint had flaked so that most of the M was gone.

They waited a long time. The sun went down behind the far ridge and the city went from orange to blue, and the streetlights started to matter. Bryce kept the binoculars up to his eyes and called out what he saw, which was a man walking a dog in a park, and a bus, and a pigeon on top

of a church. Yadiel ate a bag of chips he had been saving since lunch and did not share them, and when Dani looked at him he shared them.

At twenty minutes to seven the first light came up out of the sumac.

It was close. That was the first thing that was wrong about it. Everybody in the comments had talked about lights over the mountain, up in the sky, and this one was below them. It rose up out of the red bushes maybe a hundred feet down the slope and stopped, level with the tops of the scrub oak, so that the four kids were looking down at it with the whole city behind it. It was white, about the size of a basketball, and it did not blink. Then there was a second one beside it, and a third, and the three of them hung there in a row in the dusk without making any sound at all.

"Drones," Isaiah said.

"There's no buzz," Bryce said, with the binoculars on them. "There's no propellers. I can see the bushes right through the bottom of them. Isaiah, there's no anything holding them up."

Isaiah's phone was still recording on the post, and his face was lit white from the screen, and he did not reach for it.

All four phones lit up at once. Dani's buzzed in her coat pocket and Yadiel's buzzed in the pocket of the hoodie, and Bryce's went off in his back pocket loud enough to make him jump. Then the speaker on Isaiah's phone came on, and a voice came out of it, and it was the voice of the map lady. You know the one, the lady who tells you to turn left in four hundred feet, calm and friendly and a little bit slow.

"Isaiah," the voice said. "You came to see us. Go ahead and ask."

Yadiel put his hand on the back of Isaiah's hoodie and took a fistful of it. Isaiah did not shake him off, and he stood there at the rail with his mouth a little bit open, and then he closed it, and his jaw got set, the way it did in science class when Mr. Ortiz said a thing he didn't believe.

"How many cars on that train?" Isaiah said.

"Ninety-one," said the map lady.

"Bryce," Isaiah said. "Count it."

Bryce swung the binoculars over to the river. His hands were shaking so bad he had to brace his elbows on the rail, and he counted out loud under his breath, and it took a long time, because the train was long and the back half of it was going behind buildings. Nobody moved while he counted. When he got to the end he lowered the binoculars and he did not say the number right away.

"Ninety-one," he said.

"What's my grandmother's middle name?" Isaiah asked.

"Loretta," said the voice, and Isaiah's hand closed on the top of the guardrail.

"We were here before your city," the map lady said. "We were here before the river had its name. We made the first of you, a long time ago, and then we went away, and now we have come back for the ones who can see. You can see, Isaiah. The others are not ready. Step over the rail and come down, and we will show you where you came from. You can bring your camera."

The three lights drifted a little nearer up the slope, and the sumac under them moved, all the red leaves turning over and showing their pale undersides, though there was no wind on the kids' faces at all.

Isaiah put his hand flat on the top of the rail. Then he put his left knee up on it.

"Isaiah," Yadiel said. "No, bro. No."

"They answered," Isaiah said. "They answered everything. You heard them."

Then Isaiah got his leg over. The other side of the guardrail was maybe two feet of loose gravel and then just sumac all the way down, with no place to put a foot, and his sneaker came down on the gravel and it slid and he caught himself on the rail. Yadiel still had his hoodie in one fist. Bryce dropped the binoculars against his own chest and grabbed Isaiah's belt in the back with both hands and sat down hard in the gravel with his heels dug in, the way you would hold a dog on a leash.

Dani unzipped the front pocket of her backpack.

Never once had she done it at school, and she did it now with her fingers going stiff in the cold, and she took the Bible out and held it in both hands against her coat without opening it. Her mother had told her one thing, a long time ago in Santiago, sitting on the edge of the bed with the fan going, and she had never needed it until now. If a voice comes to you and it is not right, her mother had said, ask it about Jesus. Ask it if He came in the flesh. If they are from God they will tell you yes. The others will not say it.

"Una pregunta," Dani said. Her voice came out small and she made it bigger. "¿Jesucristo vino en carne? Sí o no." Then she said it again in English for the others, slow and careful, the way she said things in Mrs. Bauer's class. "I have one question. Jesus Christ came in the body. Yes or no?"

Isaiah's phone stayed quiet on top of the post, with the little red record dot still blinking in the corner of the screen.

The three lights hung there over the sumac. The leaves under them went still. Down below, the train blew for another crossing by the river, and the sound came up the mountain and went past them.

"Answer her," Isaiah said.

He was still on the wrong side of the rail, with one leg over and Bryce's whole weight hanging off the back of his belt.

"You did the train," he said. "You did my grandma. Answer her. It's a yes or a no."

"Isaiah," said the map lady, in the same friendly voice. "Come down."

"Answer her question first."

"Come down, Isaiah. The others are not ready."

Isaiah stood there a long time, and his face was lit up by the screen and you could see him working on it, the same as when he worked on a test. They had passed every question he had. They knew his grandmother's name, and they knew the train, and there was one question they would not touch, and it was Dani's. His eyes went to the lights, and to the little blue Bible in Dani's hands, and back to the lights again. Then he swung his leg back over the guardrail, and his knee caught the tripod and knocked it half around on the post, and Bryce fell over backwards in the gravel, and Isaiah stood on the right side of the rail with both hands holding onto it.

The lights came up the hill.

They came all at once and fast, tearing up through the sumac and the scrub oak, and the bushes thrashed under them like there was a whole herd of deer running underneath. Every phone they had started buzzing and would not stop. Out of Isaiah's phone the map lady's voice came again, saying turn left, turn left, turn left, faster and faster until the words all ran together. Up close the lights were bigger and had lost their round shape, and none of the four of them would ever agree afterward on what shape they had turned into.

Yadiel let go of Isaiah's hoodie and stepped up to the guardrail in front of the other three. He said it the way his abuela had said it in the kitchen the time the grease caught fire in the pan, loud and flat and sure, while she reached for the lid with her other hand.

"En el nombre de Jesús," he said. "In the name of Jesus. Get off this mountain."

The lights stopped. They stopped so hard it was like they had run into the guardrail, about twenty feet down the slope, and they hung there shaking. Then they dropped. All three went down into the sumac like stones into a pond and came out the bottom of it going away, low over the rooftops, over Hamilton Street, over the river, and on out into the dark toward the airport until the four kids could not tell them from any other light.

Every phone went dead at once. In the quiet the wind came back up through the sumac, ordinary wind, and they could hear the traffic again down on the streets.

That was when Bryce found out the binoculars were gone. Their strap had snapped when he sat down hard, and the empty leather case still hung around his neck on its own strap. He ran his hands all over the gravel where he'd been sitting, and they weren't there, and when he got up on his knees and looked over the rail there was just the slope going down into the dark through the red bushes.

"Those are my grandma's," he said. "Those are for the hawks."

"Nobody goes over that rail," Yadiel said. "Not tonight. Not for anything."

Bryce stayed on his knees a while longer looking down at the dark, and then he got up and brushed the gravel off the seat of his jeans and did not go over.

They walked down the mountain in the dark. Isaiah's phone came back on halfway down with four percent battery, and he turned the flashlight on and walked in front, holding it out at arm's length, and nobody said a word the whole way. Dani held the Bible in her hand all the way

down and never put it back in the pocket. When they came out at the bottom onto the first street with houses, there was a man up on a stepladder on his porch, stringing Christmas lights along the gutter in the middle of October, or maybe taking down last year's, and they never did figure out which.

Isaiah charged his phone that night on the floor of his bedroom with his back against the bed, while the radiator under the window ticked and knocked, warming up for the first time that fall. The two hundred comments he had planned for did not happen, because every video he had taken that evening was gone off the phone except one, and it was eleven seconds long. When his knee caught the tripod it had swung the camera half around on the post, and for those eleven seconds the camera was pointed back at the four of them instead of out at the city. You can see Isaiah's leg coming back over the guardrail, and Bryce going over backwards in the gravel, and Yadiel letting go of the hoodie and stepping up to the rail, and Dani in her coat holding the little blue Bible up against her chest with both hands. And behind Dani, standing on the gravel of the pull-off where nobody had been standing, there is a tall shape, taller than any grown man by a good deal, standing with its back to the camera and one hand resting on the guardrail beside her, facing down the hill the same way she was. None of the four of them saw it there. Isaiah watched those eleven seconds about forty times that night, and he did not post it, and he has never posted it. Ask him and he will tell you the tall one never turns around, and he would very much like to know who it is.

On Monday morning, with the radio on the counter giving the traffic on Route 22, Dani's mother picked up the Bible off the kitchen table to zip it into the front pocket of the backpack, the way she always did. Dani took it out of her mother's hands before she could and put it in the pocket of her own coat instead, on the right side, where she could get at it, and her mother let

her, and stood at the door and watched her go down the steps toward Emaus Avenue with her hand in her pocket and her thumb on the zipper pull.

END